the duo with authorities in Nepal, voicing concerns that Amritpal had crossed the borders and could be attempting to flee to the UK from Kathmandu.

The crackdown had started on March 18, a day after Amritsar wound up some G-20 meetings. Amritpal and his associates were slapped with serious charges under the National Security Act, including spreading disharmony, attempt to murder and attacking police personnel. Punjab Police started off on a high thereafter by claiming to dismantle the separatist network "without firing a bullet", but with Amritpal and his pal still at large, the pressure on the force and acting DGP Gaurav Yadav was beginning to tell.

And pressure has been mounting on all sides. On March 27, the head priest of the supreme Sikh council—Akal Takht jathedar Giani Harpreet Singh—issued an ultimatum warning the Punjab government that matters could escalate if every Sikh youth arrested in the case was not released immediately. On the political side, Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) chief Sukhbir Badal, on a low since his party's assembly poll decimation, has also been promising the detainees legal help. This segued right into an emotive issue that had already been simmering: that of the 'Bandi Singhs', or Sikh convicts from older terror-related cases. In fact, Amritpal hit the front pages in late February extending that very line of protest—controversially laying siege to a police station in Ajnala to get one of his aides, a kidnapping accused, released. The ensuing clashes, the force's inability to retaliate, Amritpal's aide being freed, none of it showed the cops in good light.

On March 2, the Bhagwant Mann-led state government was nudged by Union home minister Amit Shah to take action. The Centre moved 18 contingents (19,000 personnel) of the anti-riot Rapid Action Force (RAF) and paramilitary forces to Punjab. The Research and Analysis Wing (RAW), National Investigation Agency (NIA) and Intelligence Bureau (IB) provided intel support. Then started the chase after a chimera. Conspiracy theorists say the cops never had any intention of arresting Amritpal, fearing that would make him a "bigger public figure". A top cop, denying that, says intelligence spooks were tailing him and the police had laid a trap near Mehatpur village in Jalandhar where he had a preaching programme. Amritpal apparently gave them the slip, with the CCTV footage suggesting he had used link roads instead of highways to escape to Haryana, UP and maybe Nepal. But when the internet was blocked for three days in Punjab, why were the state borders not sealed? The authorities have no answer. Meanwhile, in lightning raids, 353 people across Punjab were detained for questioning—after universal flak, 197 of them have since been released.



IMAGES OF AMRITPAL HAVE BEEN LEAKED REGULARLY ON SOCIAL MEDIA SINCE THE CHASE BEGAN

Perhaps just as well, because of the impression it could create—erroneously—that he had the whole landscape backing him. Amritpal's emergence, rise and now flight have been more of a social media phenomenon than anything else. A former top cop in Punjab, who tracks his social media posts, told INDIA TODAY that most of his followers were overseas. The major reactions to the crackdown too came from pro-Khalistan activists in the UK, US, Canada and Australia. Security agencies claim Amritpal was trained by a UK-based Khalistan activist, Avtar Singh Khanda, before he arrived in India last August. On March 9, his social media manager, Gurinderpal Aujala, was nabbed at Amritsar airport—he too was apparently in touch with Khanda. The latter, who has "sought asylum" in the UK, is stated to be behind the violence at the Indian consulate in London on March 19, over which the two countries got into a diplomatic tiff, with India withdrawing security at the British mission in Delhi in a tit-for-tat move.

Of Amritpal's two mentors in India, Kulwant Singh Rauke, a known radical, has been arrested while Papanpreet is on the run with him. A cashier at the Punjab State Power Corporation, Kulwant has been charged under the NSA and shifted to the high-security Dibrugarh central jail in Assam. Punjab Police has slapped the NSA on seven people and shifted five of them to Dibrugarh jail. This includes Amritpal's uncle Harjeet Singh, actor-turned-Waris financier Daljit Singh Kalsi, Bhagwant 'Pradhanmantri' Bajeka, and close aides Bhagwant Singh and Gurmeet Singh. 'Pradhanmantri' is a social media phenomenon, though his family claims he's not "fit mentally". Even the jathedar criticised the slapping of NSA on him. "If the nation's security can be threatened by characters like Bajeka…", he left the sentence hanging.

But authorities say Amritpal was creating a private militia, stockpiling weapons, even preparing suicide bombers—and had a firing range to train those he was recruiting to the 'Anandpur Khalsa Force' from among youth turning up at a deaddiction camp he ran in his village Jallupur Khera. One of those, liquor smuggler Tejinder Gill or Gorkha Baba, who was nabbed from Khanna on March 25, is Exhibit A and is apparently singing like a canary. Dozens of raids so far have unearthed just 10 weapons, though. That too of .315 and .32 bore, hardly a cache to wage war against the state. Indeed, many theories floated by officials don't entirely add up. Amritpal's counsel has even filed a habeas corpus plea, saying the whole chase is a sham and he has been in illegal custody since March 18. The truth, for sure, was a fugitive as of mid-week. ■